The First Week: Remote Team Lead Simulation

Storyboard, Branching Map and Design Rationale

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1. Design Overview

Topic: Remote Team Collaboration and Async Communication

Format: Consequence driven simulation (about 10 to 12 minutes), no quiz, no flashcards, no linear content then test flow

Design principle: PRACTICE FIRST, CONTENT ON DEMAND. The learner acts, sees consequences, and only then pulls in reference material if they want it.

Why this differs from Projects 1 to 4: The four earlier modules share one pattern (setup, flashcards, drag and drop, quiz, scenario, checklist, assessment). This project replaces that pattern with a decision loop, live variables and a pattern based debrief. It is designed to show range, not repeat a template.

Companion piece: Part 2 is a five part microlearning series and a job aid that extend the skills practised here (see the separate curriculum document).

2. The Problem and the Learner

Business problem: Newly promoted or newly hired team leads manage people across time zones but carry in office habits: vague messages, unplanned calls, silent assumptions. The result is blocked work, missed deadlines and low trust.

Target learner: First time or early career team leads (0 to 2 years of leading others) on distributed teams of 4 to 12 people in 2 or 3 time zones.

What they already know: How to do their own job well, and basic email and chat tools.

What they lack: A repeatable way to communicate and decide when they cannot walk over to someone's desk.

Constraints: Short attention windows, mobile access likely, no appetite for long courses.

3. Learning Outcomes

By the end of the simulation, the learner will be able to:

1. **CLARIFY** an ambiguous status update by asking specific, answerable questions (what is done, what is left, what is blocking, when).
2. **DESIGN** a handoff across time zones so that work is not blocked overnight.
3. **DEESCALATE** a public disagreement by moving it to the right channel and closing the loop in writing.
4. **REPORT** upward using a structured async update (status, risks, asks).

Each outcome maps to exactly one decision day (see the alignment table in Section 8).

4. Simulation Mechanics

Role: You are Alex, a new team lead. The team: Priya (Dubai), Marcus (Toronto), Sam (Lisbon), and Dana, your director (Toronto).

Structure: Five simulated days (Monday to Friday). One key decision per day, three options each.

Visible variables (shown as three meters, updated after every decision):

Variable	Start	Meaning	Good direction
TEAM TRUST	5 / 10	How safe and respected the team feels	Higher
DEADLINE RISK	4 / 10	Likelihood the Friday deliverable slips	Lower
TEAM ENERGY	6 / 10	Workload and morale	Higher

Reference Library (on demand): A side panel with four items: Async Message Checklist, Handoff Note Template, Escalation Ladder, and BLUF Update Template. Opening an item costs nothing, but the simulation logs WHICH items the learner opened and WHEN (before or after deciding). This feeds the debrief.

Feedback style: No "correct/incorrect" banners. Learners see a short consequence scene (a reply, a chat thread, a silence) and the meters moving. Explanations appear only in the debrief.

5. Scene by Scene Storyboard

Day 1, Monday: The Kickoff (Outcome: foundation, sets the tone)

Scene: Your first team message. Priya will be online for 3 more hours, Marcus has just started his day, and Sam is midafternoon. The Friday deliverable is a client report.

Decision: How do you open the week?

- **A. Schedule a live kickoff call in 20 minutes.** Consequence: Priya joins late, Sam is already deep in other work and misses it. Trust -1, Deadline Risk +1, Energy -1.
- **B. Post a written kickoff:** goals, owners, deadlines, and a 5 minute recorded walkthrough for questions. Consequence: Replies trickle in over the day with specific questions. Trust +2, Deadline Risk -1, Energy 0.
- **C. Post a short "Welcome everyone, let's have a great week!" message.** Consequence: Three emoji reactions, zero clarity. Trust 0, Deadline Risk +1, Energy 0.

Day 2, Tuesday: The Vague Update (Outcome 1: CLARIFY)

Scene: Sam posts: "Done, mostly." Nothing else.

Decision: How do you respond?

- **A. Reply "Ok great, thanks!"** Consequence: Hidden problem surfaces later (see Day 3 variant). Trust 0, Deadline Risk +2.
- **B. Reply in thread with four specific questions:** what is finished, what remains, any blockers, expected completion. Consequence: Sam answers in full within the hour and flags a dependency on Marcus. Trust +1, Deadline Risk -2.
- **C. Ask Sam to jump on a call right now.** Consequence: Works, but pulls Sam out of focus time and sets a call first habit. Trust 0, Deadline Risk -1, Energy -1.

Day 3, Wednesday: The Overnight Block (Outcome 2: DESIGN handoffs)

Scene: Priya is blocked, waiting for Marcus's approval. It is the middle of Marcus's night. If this stays unsolved, Thursday is lost.

Decision: What do you do?

- **A. Ping Marcus directly at his 2 a.m.** Consequence: Marcus replies groggily, annoyed. Trust -2, Deadline Risk -1, Energy -1.
- **B. Write a handoff note and set a standing approval window** (Marcus approves by 9 a.m. his time; Priya gets a clear fallback if he cannot). Consequence: Priya continues with a preapproved fallback, Marcus approves at 8:40 a.m. Trust +2, Deadline Risk -2, Energy +1.
- **C. Do Priya's task yourself to keep things moving.** Consequence: It ships, but you are exhausted and the process problem remains. Trust -1, Deadline Risk -1, Energy -2.

Branch note: If the learner chose Day 2 option A, a bonus problem appears here: Sam's "mostly done" work was missing a key section, so Deadline Risk rises by an extra 2 before this decision is made.

Day 4, Thursday: The Chat Flare Up (Outcome 3: DEESCALATE)

Scene: In the team channel, Marcus and Priya exchange sharp messages about the blocked approval. Others are silent.

Decision: How do you respond?

- **A. Reply publicly, pointing out who was at fault.** Consequence: Silence, then Sam sends you a private message about feeling unsafe to post. Trust -3, Energy -2.
- **B. Speak to each person privately, then post a short written resolution and a new rule for approvals.** Consequence: Both thank you; the channel returns to normal. Trust +2, Energy +1.
- **C. Stay out of it and hope it fades.** Consequence: It fades, but Priya starts withholding updates. Trust -1, Deadline Risk +1.

Branch note: If Trust is 3 or below at the start of Day 4, the conflict escalates and an extra option appears: **D. Call an urgent all hands.** It partially repairs the situation (Trust +1, Energy -2) but is not rated as the best choice.

Day 5, Friday: The Upward Update (Outcome 4: REPORT)

Scene: Dana asks for a status update before her weekend begins in Toronto.

Decision: How do you write it?

- **A. A long narrative of everything that happened this week.** Consequence: Dana replies, "Can you summarise?" Trust -1, Deadline Risk 0.
- **B. A structured BLUF update:** Status (one line), Risks (two bullets), Asks (one decision needed from Dana). Consequence: Dana replies with a one word approval and the decision. Trust +1, Deadline Risk -1.
- **C. "All good, nothing to flag."** Consequence: Dana is surprised on Monday by the issues you did not mention. Trust -2, Deadline Risk +2.

6. Branching Map (Decision Tree)

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DAY 1: Kickoff
 ├─ A (live call) ──────────┐
 ├─ B (written + recording) ┼──> DAY 2: Vague update
 └─ C (vague welcome) ──────┘     ├─ A ("Ok great") ──> DAY 3 + EXTRA PENALTY
(missing section)
                                  ├─ B (specific questions) ──> DAY 3
(standard)
                                  └─ C (immediate call) ──> DAY 3 (standard)

DAY 3: Overnight block
 ├─ A (ping at 2 a.m.) ─┐
 ├─ B (handoff + window)┼──> DAY 4: Chat flare up
 └─ C (do it yourself) ─┘     (if Trust <= 3 → extra option D appears)
                               ├─ A (public blame)
                               ├─ B (private + written resolution)
                               └─ C (ignore)

DAY 4 ──> DAY 5: Upward update (A / B / C)

DAY 5 ──> DEBRIEF (pattern based, no pass/fail)
```

Possible endings (based on final meters):

- **Strong Week:** Trust 8 or above and Deadline Risk 3 or below.
- **Recoverable Week:** Mixed meters; the team delivers but with strain.
- **Fragile Week:** Trust 4 or below or Deadline Risk 7 or above; the debrief focuses on repair strategy.

7. Debrief Design

There is no percentage score. The debrief shows the learner's DECISION PATTERN across the five days:

- **Clarity Builder:** Chose structured, specific, written options (mostly B).
- **Fast Responder:** Favoured speed and live calls (mostly C or A on Days 1 and 2).
- **Hands On Rescuer:** Absorbed problems personally instead of fixing the process (Day 3 C).
- **Silent Observer:** Avoided or undercommunicated (Day 4 C, Day 5 C).

Each pattern includes: a plain language description, one strength, one blind spot, and one next action linked to the Reference Library item that would help most.

Reflection prompt (open response, not graded): "Which day felt hardest to decide, and what would you do differently in your real team this week?"

8. Alignment Table (Outcome, Activity, Evidence)

Outcome	Activity	Evidence of learning
1. CLARIFY	Day 2 decision	Option B chosen; Reference Library item opened before or after
2. DESIGN handoffs	Day 3 decision	Option B chosen; Deadline Risk reduced
3. DEESCALATE	Day 4 decision	Option B chosen; Trust recovered
4. REPORT	Day 5 decision	Option B chosen; Dana's response
Overall	Debrief and reflection	Pattern identified; written commitment to one change

9. Build Notes (for Storyline or Rise when access returns)

- Use Storyline variables for the three meters (Trust, Risk, Energy) and a trigger on each choice layer to update them.
- One slide per day, with chat style consequence layers; no scoring slide.
- Reference Library as a persistent slide master panel; use a variable to log which items were opened.
- Debrief slide uses conditional branching on a counter variable per option type.
- Accessibility: all meters need text equivalents; avoid colour only signalling; provide transcripts for the recorded walkthrough.

10. Design Decisions to Mention in the Portfolio Case Study

1. **Why simulation:** The skill being taught is judgment under ambiguity, which a quiz cannot assess.
2. **Why no pass/fail:** Real work rarely gives a clean score; pattern feedback is more useful.
3. **Why content on demand:** It respects experienced adult learners and gives me behavioural data on when they seek help.
4. **What I would test with real learners:** Whether the three option structure feels too obvious, and whether the extra branches on Days 3 and 4 are noticeable enough.